

Vision

Cultured Mornings seeks to prevent food insecurity and engage in social justice initiatives by creating opportunities through education; skill-building; mentoring; self-empowerment; and service-learning.

Mission

Cultured Mornings empowers youth to reach their full potential by offering practical and applicable life-skill building services with a focus on food security.

Values

Hospitality: Being of service to all people

Ujamaa: Invest in what we build together

Kuumba: To positively extend the legacy of our community

POV #01: The Transitioning Alumni

I'd like to explore ways to help **alumni navigating the transition out of the program and into adulthood to understand and access clear pathways for growth, mentorship, and career opportunities** because **they leave a strong, supportive environment but lack structure, visibility, and guidance on what comes next**
HMWs:

1. How might we make the transition from program → career pathway visible and actionable?
2. How might we connect alumni to real opportunities (jobs, catering, mentorship) at the right time?
3. How might we support alumni in navigating early adulthood beyond just culinary skills?
4. How might we reduce the drop-off after program completion?
5. How might we create a sense of continued support, not an "end" to the experience?

POV #02: The Identity-Seeking Alumni

I'd like to explore ways to help **alumni who want to feel seen, valued, and represented to express their identity, story, and growth in a meaningful digital space** because **representation is not just visual—it's about being acknowledged, understood, and reflected in the platform's tone, content, and storytelling**
HMWs:

1. How might we design a platform that reflects alumni identities, cultures, and lived experiences?
2. How might we allow users to tell their story beyond just a resume?
3. How might we highlight personal growth, not just outcomes?
4. How might we make users feel "this was made for me" the moment they enter?
5. How might we embed representation into content, language, and interactions—not just visuals?

POV #03: The Emerging Talent (Portfolio + Visibility)

I'd like to explore ways to help **alumni who are developing skills and want to be recognized as emerging talent to build, showcase, and evolve a portfolio that reflects their capabilities** because **they currently lack structured tools to document their work and be discovered by mentors or workforce partners**
HMWs:

1. How might we make portfolio-building simple, ongoing, and engaging (not a one-time task)?
2. How might we help alumni translate program experiences into professional assets?
3. How might we make talent visible to mentors and workforce partners?
4. How might we design portfolios that reflect both skill *and* personality?
5. How might we encourage consistent updates without it feeling like work?

POV #04: The Mentor Seeking Meaningful Connection

I'd like to explore ways to help **mentors, chefs, and educators who want to guide and support alumni to build meaningful, ongoing relationships in a digital environment** because **mentorship currently relies heavily on in-person interaction and lacks structure, continuity, and tools online**
HMWs:

1. How might we enable meaningful mentor–alumni relationships beyond the classroom?
2. How might we design mentorship interactions that feel natural, not transactional?
3. How might we support mentors with the right context about each alumni (goals, skills, interests)?
4. How might we make mentorship scalable without losing its personal feel?
5. How might we create moments of connection that actually matter?

POV #05: The Workforce Partner Looking for Talent

I'd like to explore ways to help **workforce partners seeking young, emerging culinary talent to easily discover, evaluate, and connect with alumni** because **there is currently no streamlined, trusted way to access this talent pipeline**
HMWs:

1. How might we make it easy for workforce partners to discover relevant talent quickly?

2. How might we design portfolios that communicate readiness, skills, and potential clearly?
3. How might we build trust between workforce partners and alumni?
4. How might we surface opportunities (jobs, gigs, catering) in a way that benefits both sides?
5. How might we incentivize partners to return and stay engaged?

1. Affinity Map (Think / Say / Do / Feel)

THINK (*beliefs, assumptions, internal thoughts*)

1. "This program is like a family"
2. "I'm learning skills that can help me in real life"
3. "This could help me get into the culinary/hospitality field"
4. "I'm not sure what happens after I finish"
5. "I don't fully know what opportunities are out there for me"
6. "I want to grow, but I don't know how to take the next step"
7. "A platform should help me connect and learn more"

SAY (*direct quotes / expressed opinions*)

1. "It's fun and very helpful"
2. "I think of learning how to cook and culture"
3. "It helps teach lifelong skills"
4. "You can put this on your resume"
5. "I don't know what happens next"
6. "I would want something that connects me to others"
7. "It should be safe but informative"
8. "I want to see what I've done"
9. "Something with games or things I'm interested in"
10. "A place I can come back to"

DO (*current behaviors*)

1. Shares experience mostly through **word of mouth**
2. Rejoins or considers rejoining programs
3. Learns cooking skills and applies them at home
4. Engages during program but **drops off after**
5. Does NOT:
6. Build portfolios
7. Use structured platforms
8. Have clear career follow-up actions
9. Looks for opportunities informally (if at all)

FEEL (*emotions, motivations, pain points*)

1. **Supported / welcomed** during the program
2. **Proud** of skills learned
3. **Curious** about future opportunities
4. **Uncertain / lost** after program ends
5. **Disconnected** once program is over
6. **Motivated but under-guided**
7. **Excited** by opportunities to be seen or recognized
8. **Encouraged** by community and representation

Competitive Analysis Summary

Key Outcomes + Strategic Opportunities for Cultured Mornings Portal

1 Core Insight

No single competitor combines:

1. Professional credibility
2. Creative portfolio storytelling
3. Mentorship structure
4. Workforce pipeline access
5. Cultural belonging

Each platform solves one piece.

Cultured Mornings has the opportunity to combine them — while centering identity, warmth, and representation.

2 Major Patterns Across Competitors

Pattern 1: Transactional Over Relational

Handshake and LinkedIn focus on opportunity exchange, not community.

Opportunity:

Cultured Mornings can prioritize relationship-building over pure job matching.

Pattern 2: Professional But Not Personal

LinkedIn emphasizes resumes.

Behance emphasizes projects.

Neither supports transitional youth identity development.

Opportunity:

Design a space that supports growth narratives, not just credentials.

Pattern 3: Mentorship is Isolated

Mentorloop provides structure but lacks portfolio and workforce integration.

Opportunity:

Integrate mentorship into the full ecosystem (portfolio + opportunity + guidance).

Pattern 4: Youth-Specific UX is Missing

Most platforms assume adult professionals.

Opportunity:

Design for:

1. First-time portfolio builders
2. Early-career confidence
3. Guided progression

③ Strategic Opportunities for Cultured Mornings

A. Create a “Guided Growth” Portal

Instead of a static profile, build:

1. Step-by-step portfolio builder
2. Prompts for storytelling
3. Skill tagging assistance
4. Visual showcase templates

Think:

Behance aesthetic + LinkedIn credibility + youth-friendly structure.

B. Build a Curated Opportunity Layer

Not a massive job board.

Instead:

1. Carefully vetted opportunities
2. Clear application steps
3. Mentorship alignment

This avoids becoming a transactional marketplace.

C. Integrate Mentorship Into the Experience

Rather than separate matching software:

1. Light milestone tracking
2. Shared project feedback
3. Optional virtual check-ins

Keep it relational, not corporate.

D. Emphasize Representation as Differentiator

Competitors lack:

1. Cultural warmth
2. Narrative identity
3. Community-rooted storytelling

Cultured Mornings can lead with:

1. Alumni features
2. Story-based profiles
3. Community highlights
4. Values embedded into UI language

Hospitality, Ujamaa, Kuumba should show up in tone and interaction design.

E. Define the Post-18 Journey

Competitors do not clearly define:

“What happens after graduation?”

Cultured Mornings can:

1. Map a visible alumni pathway
2. Show progression milestones
3. Celebrate growth over time

④ Risks to Consider

⚠ Scope Creep

Trying to be LinkedIn + Handshake + Behance + Mentorloop at once.

⚠ Technical Feasibility

Complex matching systems increase cost.

⚠ Overbuilding

Alumni may need simplicity more than complexity.

⚠ Engagement Drop-Off

Without clear incentives, portals become inactive.

⑤ Clear Positioning Statement

The Cultured Mornings Membership Portal should be:

A culturally-rooted, guided growth platform for emerging culinary and creative talent — combining portfolio storytelling, mentorship, and curated workforce access within a community-centered environment.

⑥ Immediate Next Steps to Consider

1. Prioritize V1 features (what is essential vs future)
2. Define user flows for:
3. Alumni onboarding
4. Mentor connection
5. Workforce partner browsing
6. <li da

When you think about Cultured Mornings today, what comes to mind first?

What makes you feel *represented* in a digital space?

Positive Experience & Community: Respondents primarily associate Cultured Mornings with good experiences, describing it as fun, great, and very helpful, and thinking of it as a family of people.

Culinary Learning & Skills: The organization is strongly linked to learning how to cook, gaining cooking skills, and exploring alternative recipes (like using ground chicken for meatballs).

Culture & Networking: Cultured Mornings is also top-of-mind for learning about different cultures through food and safety, and providing networking and opportunities, including field trips.

Growth & Life Skills: It is associated with personal growth in learning and teaching young youth lifelong skills applicable whether or not they pursue the Culinary field.

1. **Inclusion and Validation:** Feeling represented is primarily linked to being included in ongoing activities and communications, being seen, and being talked to. This also involves having one's name acknowledged, and the time spent being valued, as mentioned by multiple respondents.
2. **Alignment with Personal Experience:** Representation is achieved when content allows individuals to relate to something, or when their personal values and beliefs are reflected. This includes discussing personal evolution with a skill or seeing the acknowledgement of an accomplishment.
3. **Inspiration and Upliftment:** Some respondents feel represented and inspired when they see women in the community being uplifted or hearing stories of others who persevered through hardships.

After someone completes the program, what do you think currently happens next?

Continued Education/Engagement: Respondents believe that after completing the program, participants might sign up for it again, move to a more sophisticated Cultured Mornings program, or find another related program.

Alumni Status & Networking: Completion allows them to become an alumni of the program.

Skill & Certification Acquisition: Participants earn their certification through Cultured Mornings, learn practical skills (e.g., proper food cutting, seasoning, sanitation), and gain experience to put on a resume, which could lead to working in cooking environments.

Increased Awareness & Interest: Completers develop a greater awareness of the foods they eat and produce, along with a better understanding of their interests within the hospitality industry.

Life Continuation: Some respondents simply stated that participants "go on with their lives."

What feels most important *before* anything else is built?

Our secondary research shows that no existing platform combines professional visibility, portfolio storytelling, mentorship, and workforce access within a culturally rooted community experience. Platforms like LinkedIn and Handshake focus on job access and credibility, Behance emphasizes creative showcase, and Mentorloop structures mentorship — but each operates in isolation. There is a clear opportunity for Cultured Mornings to create a guided, youth-centered portal that integrates these elements while prioritizing representation, belonging, and long-term alumni connection. Rather than building a large transactional job board, the opportunity lies in creating a curated, growth-oriented ecosystem that supports alumni identity development and workforce readiness within a community-driven framework.

Community and Relationships: The most important factors before building anything are establishing a good and strong relationship with the community, developing a bond with peers or coworkers, and prioritizing the community that Cultured Mornings has already created.

Preparation and Understanding: Respondents emphasized knowing the history of the initiative, understanding its true meaning, and knowing what will be shown.

Individual Confidence: Building individual confidence is crucial, as it requires practice, self-acceptance, and encouragement to help individuals put themselves out there.

Foundation and Mindset: Establishing a solid foundation and focusing on the correct mindset were cited as essential prerequisites.

Practical Outcomes: Being able to have job opportunities was mentioned as an important factor.

Have you ever used a website or platform that *really* felt like it was made for you? What made it work?

1. **Personalized Content and Recommendations:** Platforms like WEBTOON were effective because they always showed content the respondent liked, while another respondent mentioned a website that used visual storytelling.
2. **Intuitive Navigation and Organization:** Effective platforms were well-organized, with instructions clearly listed, and broke down information into smaller, manageable pages.
3. **Relatability and Problem Solving:** One platform felt tailor-made because it presented a relatable problem followed by a guided solution and included a thorough Q&A section.
4. **Accessibility and Functionality:** Features that made platforms work included having everything accessible, guiding the user through processes, and providing a space for students to sign in and view their completed work.
5. **Lack of Suitable Platforms:** Several respondents indicated they have not yet used a website or platform that truly felt like it was made for them.

If Cultured Mornings built this portal *really well*, what impact do you hope it would have?

1. **Program Growth and Engagement:** The portal is hoped to encourage more people to join the Cultured Mornings program, increase interest in healthy cooking, and lead to seeing more students next fall, with multiple respondents expressing a desire for a lot of people joining or others starting to join.
2. **Educational Support and Career Opportunities:** Respondents hope the portal would be educational and help students who wish to enter the industry by providing exposure or opportunities to work within it.
3. **Community and Relatability:** The portal is expected to help people find others they can relate to and learn alongside.
4. **Encouragement and Benefit Awareness:** The portal is hoped to encourage young Black people, or anyone, to take advantage of the experience, emphasizing that it is a rare opportunity, and to inform them of the benefits.

Gemini for Workspace can make mistakes, including about people, so double-check it. [Learn](#)

What would make a digital space feel valuable enough for you to return to regularly?

1. **Community and Connection:** The space needs to facilitate connecting with peers and other people, emphasizing honesty and communication.
2. **Engagement and Interest:** Respondents would return regularly if the platform contained information they were personally interested in, such as content related to their hobbies, and if they felt interested in what they had learned overall.
3. **Informative Content:** Value is found in knowledge of skills from Chefs around Kentucky, intricate ideas of industry processes and impacts, contact information, and practical information like class dates and transportation needs.
4. **Learning Format:** The digital space should be safe and informative, utilizing engaging elements like games and quizzes, and offering insight into current activities or progress.
5. **Hands-on Experience:** One respondent noted the importance of incorporating or detailing in-person experiences with hands-on activities.

When you hear “Membership Portal,” what do you *expect* it to offer?

1. **Exclusive Access and Information:** Expect an exclusive digital space only accessible by members, offering specific information, such as content or resources that others cannot access, or a personal portal for individual information within the group.
2. **Career Guidance and Learning Opportunities:** Anticipate resources offering insight into program-related activities in the local area that provide strong learning experiences, and opportunities for career guidance.
3. **Community and Collaboration:** It should facilitate connections with a group of people, support group work, and allow members to share their thoughts and insights with others.
4. **Specific Program Components:** One respondent mentioned expecting a mentorship with one of the chefs.

What would make you *excited* to create or update a profile about yourself?

Personal Expression and Visibility A digital profile would be exciting if it allowed people to express themselves and show what they can really do, showcasing their skills (e.g., in the kitchen). **Tracking Growth and Activity** Excitement stems from a profile showing continuous changes and a multitude of activities, particularly those representing urgency for community building and change. **Connection and Recognition** Respondents are motivated by the prospect of having a profile just for people to know them and having everyone’s support. **Aesthetics and Design** A new look and the inclusion of photos would encourage profile creation and updates.